

DYSTOPIA

Problems for the future

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When it comes to social media and the direction we're headed towards in the future, there are a few speed bumps that are likely to cause us to veer off the road at times. At Digit we're firmly of the opinion that technology is never bad, merely the people who use it. And it's some of these technologies that we think will be misused and cause headaches for social media across the world.

Rather than give you big long-winded introductions to the technologies in question, we're going to assume you have heard of all of them and just get down to business.

FACIAL RECOGNITION

Well, actually we're talking about media parsing in general here, not just faces, but people seem the most concerned about faces. Just recently a social media user who was just having her photo clicked like a billion other people do, was [photobombed by two individuals](#)⁴ who were later accused of drugging, raping and killing another woman at Spring Break in Miami, Florida. The victim, Christine Engelhardt, 24, was found dead in her hotel room. This was a case of humans identifying the killers in photos based on information released to the public when they were being hunted.

We bring this up because Facebook already has that technology, and is pretty good at identifying people even in the background of photos. Law enforcement already have systems in place to hunt for people on CCTV based on facial structures. The



US military is said to have [advanced facial recognition technology](#)⁵ that can identify a target from a kilometer away, and is a portable system that soldiers can carry. It's only cost them a million or so dollars to create thus far, so we're not sure how good it is just yet.

However, facial recognition raises problems for kids because you don't want someone to be able to track your underage kids based on their social profiles. Apart from just facial recognition, there's also location detection technologies which if we oversimplify a great deal, are basically big data digging through billions of photos from the web, looking at check-ins and location data, and then forming 3D maps to be able to identify where in a city a person is. This is essentially forensic analysis of images and videos, but being done by algorithms that a scary amount of people on the planet can develop. If it's the police using this technology to try and figure out where a kidnapper is located in the city, that's good. If it's a predator following kids about and learning where they go based on the media they upload, that's scary!

As mentioned in a previous article, Facebook already applied for a patent to recognise brand names in the background of your picture. Why would they want to do that? Suppose a TV brand wanted to advertise to all of the users of a competitor's

products, it would first need to know who those people are who own their competitor's products. Facebook can now know that, and will charge them premium for that. And remember, not once did you agree to tell Facebook what TV brand you own...

This and more is going to be a challenge for social media in the future, especially with video being the preferred choice of content.

CRYPTO-CURRENCY

One problem that governments have is regulating social media, especially influencers and what they earn on social media. With traditional banking it's easy for governments to question their citizens about their earnings and send the tax man knocking on the door of people who are trying to hide their income. With crypto, earnings can be totally under the table, and essentially be the new



Promotional material for the Morris Coin cryptocurrency scam on Facebook, one of the many scams in India busted for luring people into investing in dubious cryptocurrencies.

black money instead of cash. Our country is especially vulnerable to this, and perhaps that's why the government is very wary of crypto currencies such as Bitcoin and others.

With crypto dealings being secure and confidential, it's no wonder that it can be used, or rather, is already being used for money laundering and other criminal activities. A [report by crypto watchdog Chainalysis](#)⁶ suggests that the US, Russia, China, South Africa and the UK (in that order) are the countries where